

Hosting & Platform Tiers

Free vs. controlled paid: a supported approach

Prepared for [Institution]

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The short version

The proposed stack (GitHub + Cloudflare) is enterprise-grade **even on its free tiers**: the same infrastructure that serves major companies. But “free” can read as “hobby project” to a board, and it doesn’t come with a **support commitment**. So this document lays out both a fully-free path and a **controlled paid path** that buys four things an institution genuinely wants:

- **A support SLA**: a vendor obligation to respond, not just a community forum.
- **Security**: a managed Web Application Firewall (WAF).
- **Accountability**: richer analytics and audit/governance features.
- **Optics**: a defensible, paid, supported posture.

Even the controlled paid path typically lands **at or below** current BlueHost/WordPress spend, with dramatically less maintenance.

Pricing below is current as of **August 2026**; confirm current rates before finalising (sources listed at the end).

GitHub tiers

GitHub stores the website’s content and history (and is its backup).

Tier	Price	What it adds	Support
Free	\$0	Unlimited private repos & collaborators; branch protection on <i>public</i> repos; 2,000 Actions min/mo	Community forum
Team	\$4 / user / mo	Branch protection & required reviews on private repos, CODEOWNERS, 3,000 Actions min/mo	Web/email support
Enterprise	from \$21 / user / mo	SSO/SAML, audit-log API, 50,000 Actions min/mo	24/7 premium options

Nonprofit discount (note the exclusion): verified 501(c)(3) organisations can get the **Team plan free** through *GitHub for Nonprofits* (or 25% off Enterprise). **However, GitHub excludes organisations with religious affiliation**, so a church such as [Institution] is **not eligible**. That is not a problem here: GitHub **Free** (\$0) is enough for this site (public repo, one or two editors), and Team is an optional **\$4/user/mo** only if branch-protection governance is later wanted.

Cloudflare tiers

Cloudflare builds and hosts the site and serves it worldwide.

Tier	Price	What it adds	Support
Pages Free	\$0	Unlimited bandwidth & requests, 500 builds/mo, global CDN, automatic SSL, DDoS protection	Community
Workers Paid	\$5 / mo	5,000 builds/mo, higher limits (headroom for frequent edits / future functions)	Community
Pro (per domain)	\$20 / mo (annual) · \$25 monthly	WAF with managed rulesets , image optimization (Polish/Mirage), enhanced analytics , 20 WAF custom rules	Faster (email/chat)
Business (per domain)	\$200 / mo (annual) · \$250 monthly	Custom WAF rules, 100% uptime SLA , prioritised support	Priority

For an informational nonprofit site, **Pro is the meaningful “controlled paid” step**: it adds the managed WAF (security), better analytics (accountability), and quicker support, without the Business-tier cost (aimed at e-commerce/SaaS).

Two recommended configurations

Option A: Lean (fully free)

Component	Tier	Cost
GitHub	Free	\$0
Cloudflare	Pages Free	\$0
Total		\$0 / mo

Genuinely production-grade. Best when budget is the top priority. Trade-off: no support SLA, no managed WAF, community-only support.

Option B: Controlled Paid (*recommended for the pitch*)

Component	Tier	Cost
GitHub	Free (Team optional, \$4/user/mo)	\$0
Cloudflare	Pro (1 domain)	~\$20 / mo
Cloudflare	Workers Paid (build headroom)	\$5 / mo (<i>optional</i>)
Total		~\$20–25 / mo (~\$240–300 / yr)

Adds the managed **WAF**, **enhanced analytics**, and **faster support** on top of GitHub's free tier (Team's governance features are an optional \$4/user/mo).

Cost comparison vs. today

Solution	Typical annual cost	Maintenance burden
BlueHost + WordPress (current)	~\$150–400/yr (hosting + renewals; more with premium plugins/security)	High. Updates, plugins, security patching, backups
Option A: Lean	\$0	Minimal. No server, no database, no patching
Option B: Controlled Paid	~\$240–300	Minimal, plus a support SLA and managed WAF

Even Option B is **comparable to or cheaper than** the current setup, and both options remove the ongoing WordPress maintenance/security burden entirely.

Could we serve it from a host we already have?

A fair question: the site is just static files, so almost any web host can serve it, including BlueHost or a host like Reclaim. The distinction that matters is **build-and-serve vs. serve-only**.

- **Managed static hosts** (Cloudflare Pages, Netlify, GitHub Pages) watch the Git repo, **build the site automatically on every edit**, and serve it from a global CDN. This is what makes the editor workflow “save and it is live.”
- **Shared hosts** (BlueHost, Reclaim) **serve files** but do not build Hugo for you. To use one, you add an external build step (e.g. GitHub Actions) that compiles the site and copies the files to the host by FTP or Git. It works, but it is more moving parts, and you still have no global CDN.

In every option, the GitHub repo stays. It is the content source of truth and the editor (CMS) backend; the host only changes where the built files are served. Dropping GitHub would mean giving up the Git-based editing workflow.

Option	Cost	Auto-build on edit	Global CDN	Notes
Cloudflare Pages	Free, or ~\$20/mo Pro	Yes, built in	Yes	Purpose-built; recommended
GitHub Pages	Free	Via Actions workflow	Yes	No _redirects; private repo needs a paid plan
Netlify	Free (~15 GB/mo credits), or ~\$15–19/member/mo	Yes, built in	Yes	Metered bandwidth + overages; built-in Forms
BlueHost (current)	~\$9/mo renewal (~\$108/yr)	No; needs Actions + FTP deploy	No	cPanel/LAMP; keeps the renewal pricing and account upkeep you are leaving
Reclaim Hosting	~\$36/yr	Via cPanel Git or Actions	No	Education / “own your data” ethos; cheap and friendly; still no CDN or built-in pipeline
AWS S3 + CloudFront	A few \$/yr (usage)	Via Actions	Yes	Cheapest at scale, but complex AWS setup

BlueHost specifically: you can drop the built files into `public_html` and it will serve them. But you keep paying shared-hosting renewal prices (roughly \$9/mo after intro rates), keep managing a cPanel/LAMP account, and get no CDN. That is paying more for less than a purpose-built static host, and it keeps you on the very treadmill this migration is meant to end.

Reclaim specifically: a credible, low-cost option (~\$36/yr) with a strong “own your data” and education ethos, plus cPanel Git support that can auto-deploy on push. If the institution wants a single, values-aligned vendor and is happy without a global CDN, Reclaim plus a small GitHub

Actions build step is a reasonable alternative to Cloudflare Pages. It is cheaper than BlueHost and friendlier, but it is still serve-only and lacks the integrated build, preview, and CDN of a purpose-built static host.

Bottom line: serving from an existing shared host is possible and, in Reclaim's case, even attractive on cost and ethos. But the purpose-built static hosts remain the simplest and fastest: free or near-free, a global CDN, and the automatic build-on-edit pipeline that makes the editor experience seamless.

Cloudflare Pages vs. Netlify

Netlify is the closest managed-host alternative and a fine choice. Cloudflare wins here on **cost predictability**: Cloudflare Pages has unlimited, unmetered bandwidth at every tier, while Netlify's free tier (changed in Sept 2025) now runs on a credit model of roughly 15 GB/month and meters overages, with paid plans billed per team member. For a low-traffic nonprofit that could see an occasional spike, flat and unmetered removes any surprise-bill risk. Netlify's built-in Forms is its main perk, but this site has no form needs, and a form could be added to Cloudflare in a few lines via a Worker or a free service (Formspree, Basin) if one were ever wanted.

The AWS option in detail

Amazon S3 + CloudFront is the cheapest and most scalable option, but the highest-setup:

- **How it works:** GitHub Actions builds the site on each push and syncs the output to an S3 bucket; CloudFront serves it globally over HTTPS (certificate via ACM), optionally with Route 53 for DNS.
- **Cost:** effectively \$0–1/month for a small site (AWS's always-free tier covers 1 TB/month of CloudFront transfer; S3 storage is pennies). Route 53, if used, is about \$6/year.
- **Trade-offs:** you assemble and maintain four-plus services (S3, CloudFront, ACM, IAM, optionally Route 53) and the deploy pipeline yourself, with a larger security/permissions surface and paid-only AWS support. It makes sense mainly if the institution already runs on AWS.

Both still use the GitHub repo as their source (see the note above).

Domain registration (separate from hosting)

Domain **registration** (the annual fee to own the name) is separate from **hosting** (serving the site) and **DNS** (routing the name). They can live in different places or be consolidated.

Current situation (verified by WHOIS): the domain is registered with **BlueHost**, the same vendor as the current hosting. Its real cost is BlueHost's domain renewal (roughly \$18 to \$22/year for a .com).

Confirmed solicitation, do not pay: a separate **\$224/year invoice from "American Domain Services"** is *not* from BlueHost and is not a real renewal. WHOIS confirms BlueHost is the registrar, so this notice is a deceptive third-party solicitation of the well-known domain-renewal scam type. It should be ignored and reported, never paid. (If it has been paid in prior years, that was money never owed.)

Recommendation: re-home to an at-cost registrar. When moving off BlueHost, transfer the domain to Cloudflare Registrar, which sells at wholesale with no markup: about **\$10/year for a .com**, WHOIS privacy included, and no first-year-to-renewal price jump. It requires the domain to use Cloudflare DNS, which this plan already does. Alternatives: Porkbun or Namecheap (~\$10 to \$15/year).

Total cost of ownership (hosting + domain)

Scenario	Hosting	Domain	Total / year
Today (BlueHost hosting + BlueHost .com)	~\$108	~\$20	~\$128
Proposed, Lean (Cloudflare Free + at-cost .com)	\$0	~\$10	~\$10
Proposed, Controlled Paid (Cloudflare Pro + at-cost .com)	~\$240	~\$10	~\$250

The Lean path is roughly **\$10/year all-in**; the paid, supported path lands near today's legitimate spend while removing the maintenance burden. Separately, and importantly, dropping the bogus **\$224/year "American Domain Services" invoice** (see above) eliminates a recurring charge that was never legitimate in the first place.

What each paid dollar buys (the board's questions)

- **"Is anyone accountable if it breaks?"** ☐ Cloudflare Pro adds a faster support channel; Business adds a 100% uptime SLA if ever needed.
- **"Is it secure?"** ☐ Static sites already have almost no attack surface; Pro adds a **managed WAF** on top, plus DDoS protection at every tier.
- **"Can we see how it's doing?"** ☐ Pro's enhanced analytics; GitHub's history is a full audit trail of every change.
- **"Are we depending on one person / a free hobby account?"** ☐ No: accounts are **institution-owned** with a second owner, and every change is versioned in Git. Branch-protection governance is available on GitHub Team (\$4/user/mo) if wanted.

Recommendation

Adopt **Option B (Controlled Paid)** for launch: GitHub Free (repo + editor backend), and **Cloudflare Pro (~\$20/mo)** for the WAF, analytics, and support posture. It answers the board's accountability and security questions, presents as a serious supported solution, and still costs the same

or less than BlueHost/WordPress, with a fraction of the upkeep. Downgrading to the fully-free Option A later is a one-click change with no migration.

Sources

- GitHub pricing: <https://github.com/pricing>
- GitHub for Nonprofits: <https://github.com/solutions/industry/nonprofits>
- Cloudflare Pages / Workers pricing: <https://developers.cloudflare.com/workers/platform/pricing/>
- Cloudflare plan comparison (Pro/Business): <https://www.cloudflare.com/plans/>

Figures current as of August 2026; verify before final circulation.